A LONG JOURNEY

A TIMELINE OF THE WRESTLERS' PROTRACTED STRUGGLE FOR JUSTICE



Dec. 2022

Wrestlers approach the Wrestling Federation of India's (WFI) sexual harrasment committee, but realising that four of its five members are men and WFI president Brij Bhushan Singh's aides, they choose to take their protest to the streets

Apr. 24

Sports ministry reveals one of the OC's findings—that the WFI didn't form an ICC as mandated under the Prevention of Sexual Harassment Act. Meanwhile, wrestlers move SC seeking an FIR against Singh

Apr. 25

The top court issues a notice over the wrestlers' plea



Apr. 27



Indian Olympic Association (IOA) president **P.T. Usha** calls the protest "gross indiscipline" that tarnishes the country's image

Apr. 28

Delhi Police finally file two FIRs against Singh—one under PoCSO Act and another under IPC Sections 354A (making sexually-coloured remarks) and 354D (stalking). WFI assistant secretary Vinod Tomar is also booked

Apr. 29

Despairing at the lack of progress, wrestlers accept political support. **Priyanka Gandhi-Vadra** visits the protest site and consoles Sakshi and Vinesh. Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal also expresses solidarity



May. 12

An ad hoc committee formed by the IOA takes charge of the WFI until next elections (announced for July 6)

May 28

As Singh attends the inauguration of the new Parliament complex, the wrestlers march to the site, only to be detained by Delhi Police. **Visuals of them being mishandled** shock the nation. The Jantar Mantar protest site is cleared and FIRs are filed against wrestlers for defying police orders and assaulting women officers



May 30

Wrestlers reach Haridwar to immerse their medals in the Ganga. Naresh Tikait, leader of the Bharat Kisan Union, dissuades them at the last moment and declares that the government has five days to act

victims. Initially, they planned to complain to the five-member sexual harassment committee at the WFI, whose members included secretary general N. Prasood, joint secretary Jai Prakash, executive members Vishal Singh, Debendra Kumar Sahoo and Sakshi Malik. It wasn't quite the internal complaints committee (ICC) mandated by the PoSH (Prevention of Sexual Harassment) Act, 2013, per which at least half of the members have to be women and which must include an external representative associated with an NGO or an association that works for women. Realising that only one person—Malik, who says she wasn't even aware she was on the committee—was a woman and also the only one likely to seek action against Singh, the wrestlers decided to take their fight to the streets instead, seeing it as their only recourse for justice.

BATTLING PREJUDICES

The decision to speak out against sexual harassment is in itself a daunting one. As one of India's eminent sport lawyers who is also associated with a top sports organisation, put it, "The best an ICC can do is report the findings back to the employer, and it is in their hands to take action. The real challenge is, who will do anything against a person who